This is a substantial soup that is a meal in itself. Mix and match whatever vegetables are in season—zucchini, cabbage, and leeks are all excellent in a minestrone.

minestrone soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 20 MINS, PLUS 8 HOURS SOAKING **COOK** 1¾ HRS **FREEZE** UP TO 1 MONTH AT THE END OF STEP 2

3½oz (100g) dried white cannellini beans
2 tbsp olive oil
2 celery ribs, finely chopped
2 carrots, finely chopped
1 onion, finely chopped
1 x 14½oz (400g) can chopped tomatoes
2½ cups hot vegetable stock or chicken stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2oz (60g) small short-cut pasta
4 tbsp chopped flat-leaf parsley
1½oz (40g) Parmesan, finely grated

1 Put the dried beans in a large bowl, cover with cold water, and leave to soak in the fridge for at least 8 hours or overnight. Drain the beans, then place them in a large saucepan and cover with cold water. Bring to a boil, then boil hard for 10 minutes, skimming the surface of any foam with a slotted spoon. Lower the heat, partially cover the pan, and simmer for 1 hour or until the beans are tender. Drain and set aside.

2 Heat the oil in the rinsed-out pan over medium heat. Add the celery, carrots, and onion, and cook, stirring occasionally, for 5 minutes or until tender. Stir in the cooked beans, then add the tomatoes and their juice, the stock, and some salt and freshly ground black pepper. Bring to a boil, stirring all the time, then cover with a lid and simmer for 20 minutes.

3 Add the pasta and simmer for 10–15 minutes or until it is cooked but still firm to the bite. Stir in the parsley and half the Parmesan, then adjust the seasoning. Serve hot, sprinkled with the remaining Parmesan.